CHAPTER 1

Why Elixir? Why Now?

Elixir has emerged over the past few years as a "most loved" language[1] that's used by many businesses and hobbyists to write reliable software systems. Many Elixirists consider it their superpower of productivity and stability. Hopefully, by the end of this book, you'll see why this is the case.

It's hard to learn a new language, harder to become production-ready with it, and even harder still to convince your boss to actually let you use the new language in production. The juice is worth the squeeze, though. Elixir opens a new way of thinking about programming that carries over into other languages as well.

Your knowledge of Ruby influences how you view and write in other programming languages. Similarly, as you develop an understanding of Elixir, it will also influence how you think when writing code. Even if you were to never use Elixir in production, you'll still benefit and grow as a programmer.

We'll start this chapter by taking a look at what makes Ruby such a great language. You'll see why Elixir is a similarly great language and why its future is bright. You'll learn about the technology that Elixir is built on top of: Erlang, OTP, and the BEAM. Finally, you'll write a bit of Elixir code and run it on your computer.

Before we talk about Elixir, let's talk about Ruby.

The Joy of Ruby

Some people have pitted Elixir as being "against Ruby," but that's not the case. When you learn a new language, it doesn't have to come with a reduced respect for what you used in the past. It also doesn't mean that you can't use

1. https://survey.stackoverflow.co/2022/#technology-most-loved-dreaded-and-wanted